

CURRENT AFFAIRS



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&
HOW ?**



3rd WEEK

14th January to 20th January, 2019

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Supreme Court orders the demolition of entire boundary wall built by NRL.

FALLS WITHIN NDZ OF KAZIRANGA!



1 Supreme Court dismissed the appeal by Numaligarh Refinery Limited and ordered demolition of 2.2 km boundary wall erected on an elephant migration corridor.

2 The refinery erected boundary wall in 2011 for the proposed township.

3 In August, 2016, NGT ordered NRL to demolish the wall within a month, but only 289 mts stretch was demolished.

4 The Supreme Court observed that the elephants do not go to office in designated route. We cannot encroach upon elephant's area, says the Apex Court.

5 It falls in the No Development Zone around Kaziranga National Park declared by the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change in 1996.

Japan decided to come out of International Whaling Commission.



Most whale species are not endangered and eating whale is part of Japanese culture, says Japan.

INTERNATIONAL WHALING COMMISSION

- It was established in 1946 with 89-member governments to conserve whales and manage whaling around the World.
- IWC regulates hunting of 13 species of great whales and not reached consensus over the regulation of smaller species.

IMPORTANT IN THE FOOD CHAIN

- Whales are at the top of the food chain, they feed on fish and invertebrates.
- When they die, their carcasses serve as food to a host of scavenger organisms, who decompose them into nutrients available for other organisms.

499

ISSUE

10% reservation for EWS Category was challenged in the Supreme Court, just 24 hours after it was swiftly piloted through both Houses of Parliament.



103rd Amendment Act grants 10% reservations to EWS in General Category.

SALIENT POINTS

- The Petitioner, Youth For Equality, contended that the Bill violates the basic features of the Constitution and contradicts several Supreme Court judgments protecting the fundamental rights.
- The nine judge Bench judgment in the Indra Sawhney case settled the law that economic backwardness could not be the sole basis for reservation.

Upset over the continued delays by New Delhi in exchanging demonetized currency, Nepal said, it will not accept high denomination Indian currency, until the Government gives specific assurance against the future shocks.



Indian currency is freely accepted in Nepal.

SALIENT POINTS

- There is two-year old demand of Nepal for return of more than Rs. 7 Cr in demonetized notes held officially by the Nepal Rastra Bank.
- Now, Nepal decided to ban all Indian currency of denominations above Rs. 100.
- Countries such as Bhutan, Nepal and Myanmar were left holding large sums of currency at the time of demonetization.
- The issue was settled with Bhutan, but, it is yet to settle with Nepal.

501 ISSUE

ISRO said that the work on Gaganyaan, the project to send Manned Mission to Space by 2022, would start soon.

**SALIENT POINTS**

- Human Space Flight Centre will be based in Bengaluru and headed by Unnikrishnan Nair.
- The facility will have dedicated team and ISRO plans to deploy around 800 to 900 scientific manpower.
- ISRO's Indian Institute of Space Science and Technology produces around 100 space engineers each year.

Cost of the Project is Rs. 9,023 Cr.



SALIENT POINTS (... Contd)

- GSLV Mark III will be used. It will have two non-crew flights in December 2020 and July 2021.
- The actual flight with crew is expected to take place in December 2021.
- Three astronauts will be given training at Institute of Aerospace Medicine, Bengaluru.
- Advanced training could be offered in Russia.

502 ISSUE

There is no consensus on GST on under-construction flats. The GST Council referred the matter to a Group of States' Finance Ministers.

THREE LAYERED STRUCTURE**NO GST**

No GST on sale of complex / building and ready-to-move-in flats, where sale takes place after the issue of completion certificate by the competent authority.

GST APPLICABILITY

- It is applicable on sale of under-construction property or ready-to-move-in flats, where completion certificate has not been issued at the time of sale.
- GST rate for such flats is 18%, but effective rate is 12% after abatement of 33% (for the cost of land).

AFFORDABLE HOUSING

- Effective rate is 8%.
- Both under-construction property and Affordable Housing have full Input Tax Credit.

The Economist Intelligence Unit released the “Democracy Index”.

The
Economist

INTELLIGENCE
UNIT

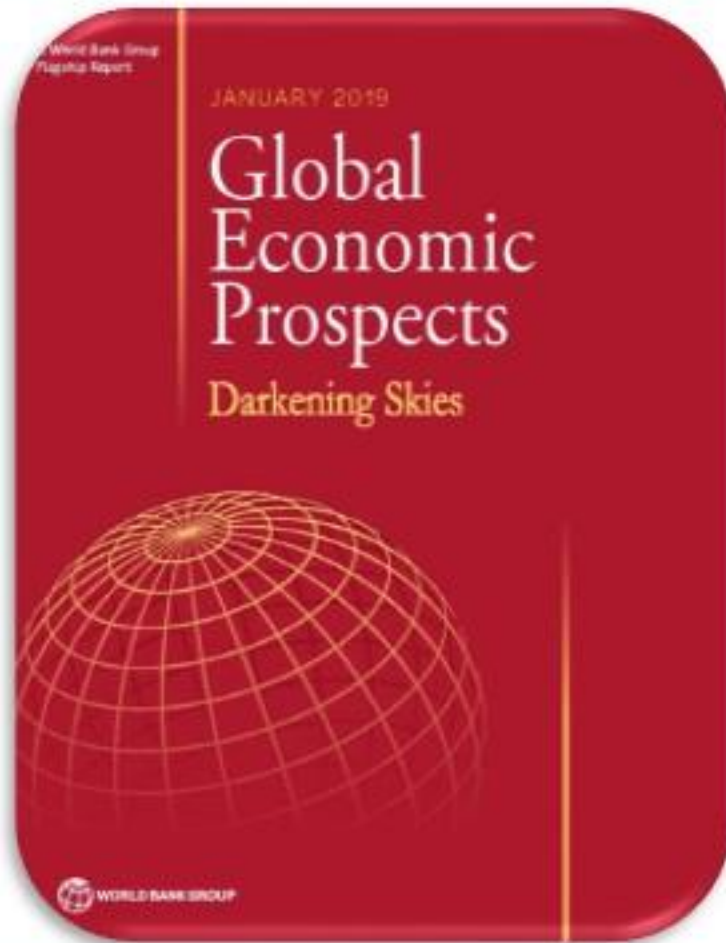


- Full Democracy
- Flawed Democracy
- Hybrid Regime
- Authoritarian Regime

SALIENT POINTS

- It ranked 165 independent states and two territories by 60 indicators across 5 broad categories —
 1. Electoral Process and Pluralism
 2. Functioning of Government
 3. Political Participation
 4. Political Culture
 5. Civil Liberties
- Only 4.5% of the World's population live in a fully democratic country.
- India is at the 41st place with a score of 7.23/10 and was placed in the flawed democracies category.
- Norway, Iceland, Sweden are in the top three positions.

World Bank released Global Economic Prospects Report, 2019 titled “Darkening Skies”.



SALIENT POINTS

- Growth among the advanced economies is expected to drop to 2%.
- Slowing external demand, rising borrowing costs and persistent policy uncertainties may weigh on the outlook for emerging market and developing economies.
- The World Bank has warned that the projected gradual deceleration of the global economic activity over the forecast horizon could be more severe than expected because of the predominance of substantial downside risks.

“Almost 16,000 desalination plants worldwide produce higher than expected flows of salty waste water and toxic chemicals and they are damaging the Environment”, says UN Study.



Global sea water has around 3.5% salt.

SALIENT POINTS

- Desalination plants pump-out 142-million cubic meters of salty brine everyday to produce 95 million cubic meters of fresh water.
- About 55% of the brine is produced in desalination plants processing seawater in Saudi Arabia, UAE and Qatar alone.

WHAT IS THE PROBLEM WITH DESALINATION PLANTS?



- 1** The hyper-salty water is mostly pumped into the sea.
- 2** Brine, water comprising about 5% salt, often includes toxins such as chlorine and copper used in desalination.
- 3** Waste chemicals accumulate in the environment and can have toxic affects on fish.
- 4** Brine can cut levels of oxygen in seawater near desalination plants with profound impacts on shellfish, crabs and other creatures on the seabed.
- 5** It leads to ecological effects observable throughout the food chain.

A web-based single window system PARIVESH is being rolled out at the State-level to speed up environmental clearances.



SALIENT POINTS

- It is currently operational at the Central level.
- It was developed under the Digital India initiative.
- It automates the entire process of submitting the application and tracking the status of such proposals at each stage of processing.

PARIVESH stands for Pro-Active and Responsive facilitation by Interactive, Virtuous and Environmental Single-window Hub.



WHAT ARE THE SPECIFIC FEATURES?



Ministry of Environment,
Forest and Climate Change
Government of India



PARIVESH

1 It is a work flow based application, based on the concept of web architecture.

2 It is to give various types of clearances like Environment, Forest, Wildlife as well as Coastal Regulation Zone from Central, State, and District-Level authorities.

3 It is single registration and single sign-in for all types of clearances.

5 It is to strengthen Sustainable Development through e-Governance.

4 It is unique-ID for all types of clearances required for a particular project.



To further improve the Ease of Doing Business in our Country, RBI drawn up a new ECB framework allowing all eligible borrowers to raise up to \$ 750 million per financial year under the automatic route.



*Minimum Maturity
Period for ECB will be
3 years.*

SALIENT POINTS

- It replaced the existing sector wise limits.
- It also expanded the list of eligible borrowers and recognized lenders.
- It also allows public sector oil marketing companies to raise ECB, with an overall ceiling of \$ 10 billion, for working capital purposes with Minimum Average Maturity Period of 3 years under the automatic route without mandatory hedging and individual limit requirements.
- The framework allows manufacturing companies to raise up to \$ 50 million per financial year with a maturity period of one year.

Government eased the norms under which start-ups can apply for exemption from the Angel Tax, which would otherwise be applicable to them.



SALIENT POINTS

- Start-ups, whose aggregate amount of paid-up share capital and share premium after the proposed issue of shares does not exceed Rs. 10 Cr, are eligible for the exemption.
- On the investor side, the angel investor should have filed IT returns of at least Rs. 50 lakh for the year preceding the year in which the investment was made.
- The investor's net worth should be at least Rs. 2 Cr or the amount of investment made in the start-up, whichever is higher.
- To claim the exemption, start-ups and investors have to make an application to the DIPP, in the prescribed format.

The Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change opposed a proposal to construct elevated roads through the Bandipur Tiger Reserve.



Ministry of Environment,
Forest and Climate Change
Government of India



Any infrastructure project through the forests is bound to impact the wildlife habitat and should be dropped.

SALIENT POINTS

- The Tiger Reserve is spread over nearly 912 sq kms, it is in Chamarajanagar District of Karnataka.
- It constitutes important component of forest landscape comprising Nagarhole, Karnataka, Mudumalai and Sathyamangalam in Tamil Nadu and Wayanad, Kerala.
- It is home to nearly 120 to 150 tigers as per 2014 estimates by NTCA.
- It also supports around 1,600 elephants.



WHAT IS THE HISTORY OF THIS ISSUE?



- 1 There is a ban on traffic through Bandipur, located 80 kms from Mysore in Karnataka, from 9 PM to 6 AM.
- 2 It is to reduce disturbance to wildlife and curb the road kills.

- 3 It is in place since 2009.
- 4 Kerala Government challenged the High Court order in this context in the Supreme Court on the grounds that it was impeding the economic growth of region.
- 5 Supreme Court constituted the committee to examine the dispute between Karnataka and Kerala.
- 6 Ministry of Road Transport and Highways proposed elevated highways, 5 sections of 1 km each.

*Now the Environment Ministry
opposed the proposal*

WHAT ARE THE ARGUMENTS OF THE ENVIRONMENTAL ACTIVISTS?



1 The infrastructure projects are prohibited under the Eco Sensitive Zone rules of Bandipur issued in September, 2011.

2 In the areas of threatened taxa, there should not be infrastructure development.

3 It is a source habitat for tigers and flyovers cannot be constructed.

4 It also ignored the Tiger Conservation Plan for Bandipur, which was prepared under Section 38V (3) of the Wildlife Protection Act, 1972, which recommended night closure of highways passing through the Tiger Reserve.

Urban Heat Islands are in the news and these are nothing but urban areas, which are significantly warmer than their surrounding rural areas.

SALIENT POINTS

- Green vegetation and water bodies are often lost as built-up areas in a city increase.
- Radiation from cemented floors, roads and buildings add to the temperature.
- This leads to a surge in surface and air temperatures causing Urban Heat Islands to form.



WHAT NEEDS TO BE DONE TO PREVENT URBAN HEAT ISLANDS?



1 Proper Zonal Planning should accommodate sufficient green spaces, such as urban greenery and water bodies. They can prevent the emergence of more Urban Heat Islands in the future.

2 Smart and energy-efficient construction materials and green roofs may also substantially help prevent the emergences of Urban Heat Islands.

The Global Risks Report 2019 was released by the World Economic Forum.

The Global Risks
Report 2019
14th Edition



WORLD
ECONOMIC
FORUM

Strategic Partner
of the Report

Global Risks Report 2019 was prepared based on the survey of nearly thousand experts and decision makers from across the World.

SALIENT POINTS

- It describes changes occurring in the global risks landscape from year to year and identifies global catastrophic risks.
- The report examines interconnectedness of risks and considers how the strategies for the mitigation of global risks might be structured.

GLOBAL RISKS REPORT 2019

WORLD
ECONOMIC
FORUM

IMPORTANT
FINDINGS!

1

Top 5 risks are ..

- Changing climate
- Raising cyber dependency
- Increasing polarisation of societies.
- Rising income and wealth disparity
- Increasing national sentiments

2

Rising geopolitical and geo-economic tensions are the most urgent risk in 2019.



The Parliament of Macedonia has passed the resolution to amend the Constitution of the Country to rename it as the Republic of Northern Macedonia.



SALIENT POINTS

The renaming is in line with a landmark agreement with Greece to end the decades long dispute.



WHAT IS THE DISPUTE BETWEEN GREECE & MACEDONIA?



ANCIENT PHILIPPI



- Macedonia got independence from Yugoslavia in 1991.
- Greece also has a region called Macedonia.
- It is in the northern mountainous part of the country and includes Greece's second largest, Thessaloniki and ancient Philippi, a UNESCO World Heritage Site.
- The UN was calling Macedonia as "Former Yugoslav Republic of Macedonia (FYROM)".
- In addition to causing confusion, the similar names have been a stumbling block for the nation of Macedonia to join the European Union and NATO, because of Greece's objections.

Historic agreement was signed in 2018 to end the dispute.

To meet India's long term energy requirements, the Prime Minister signed a pact with Uzbekistan President for import of uranium from the Central Asian Country.



SALIENT POINTS

- The agreement was signed at an event on the sidelines of Vibrant Gujarat Global Summit.
- Uzbekistan President, Mr. Mirziyoyev was one of the chief guests.
- In addition, a deal for \$ 200 million credit for housing projects in Uzbekistan was also signed.

Palestine has taken over the Chairmanship of G77 from Egypt.



It is based on the system of geographical rotation. 2019 is Asia's turn.

SALIENT POINTS

- G77 is the coalition of 134 developing countries at the United Nations.
- They speak in a single voice before 193-member General Assembly.
- It was formed in 1964 by the Joint Declaration of the Seventy-Seven Countries issued at UNCTAD.
- It was credited with a common stance against apartheid and for supporting global disarmament.

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